

Abstract

Michael Kerr presents a webinar on emotional regression as a unifying concept for understanding disturbance across biological, familial, and societal systems. Kerr argues that societal regression, driven by chronic anxiety and imbalance between counterbalancing life forces, provides a framework for understanding contemporary polarization and dysfunction without resorting to blame or cause-and-effect thinking.

Kerr begins by establishing the theoretical foundations of Bowen family systems theory, particularly the concept of counterbalancing forces between individuality and togetherness that operate across all human systems. He then expands this framework to societal functioning, demonstrating how heightened chronic anxiety pushes societies toward emotionally reactive, short-term decision-making that undermines cooperation and problem-solving. Kerr illustrates this pattern through a detailed analysis of family dynamics in delinquency, showing how overly anxious parental involvement creates a cycle of entitlement and behavioral deterioration that eventually infects broader social institutions, including courts. He connects this family-level process to societal regression by arguing that when courts begin to mirror the dysfunctional patterns of anxious parents, the entire society has become infected by regression.

Kerr then introduces cancer biology as a parallel system demonstrating the same counterbalancing logic. Drawing on Italian systems biologist Maria Bertoloso's work, he shows how cancer emerges from imbalance between differentiation and state-holding processes in cells, mirroring the imbalance between individuality and togetherness in families and societies. Kerr presents the ground finch study from Daphne Major as evidence that behavioral regression occurs across species when external environmental regulation is removed, suggesting that human disharmony with nature—through resource depletion and technological bypass of natural limits—generates the chronic anxiety underlying societal regression. He concludes that viewing current global dysfunction through the lens of systems thinking and emotional regression offers perspective and objectivity that blame-focused approaches cannot provide.